

The Wikipedia in Your Palm!

That's the WikiReader. A 127-gram electronic device with dimensions of 10x10x2 cm that contains the complete English language entries from Wikipedia.org.

When I was younger, the only places I could access the volumes of the Encyclopaedia Britannica were the school library and an uncle's place.

Maybe I was just plain uninterested, or dumb—take your pick—I never fancied taking those hard covers out of the shelves to peek at what lay inside. Maybe all those fat volumes made me nervous, to begin with.

Fast forward to today; my dependence on Wikipedia is only next to Google. Whether I want to read up on musicians, places or software projects, Wikipedia pretty much has my requirements covered—that too, with enough citations to refer me to other places, if I'm interested.

So when the WikiReader (thewikireader.com) was announced a few months back—by the same folks who're behind the OpenMoko (Om) initiative—it was time for all Wikipedia fans (including myself) to rejoice. This device claimed to fit in more than

three million English entries on the Wikipedia into a pocket-sized electronic device. What's more, it didn't require any form of connectivity at all—the articles being stored in a microSD card.

The great news is that we can now grab this device in India! Jaipur-based IDA Systems has started distributing it for Rs 5,500, inclusive of taxes and shipping charges [www.idasystems.net/wikireader]. If this seems like a steep charge, consider this: the Encyclopaedia Britannica costs Rs 63,000! Compared to that, the WikiReader seems quite easy on the pocket. Besides, a couple of night outs at a decent restaurant and you end up spending more than five grand. Still think the price is too steep? Anyway, since IDA sent a piece to us to review, I might as well get on with it.

The device comes in a no-nonsense black and white paper box with WikiReader written in bold—top, front side—and a picture of the device with the tagline "Wikipedia In Your Pocket" in the centre. Nice to see things being kept clean and simple.

Open the box and take out the cardboard tray that holds the device inside a polypack, along with a 20-page manual with very basic information on how to get started. You can make out by the size of a manual how easy or difficult it will be to get started with a device.

As you can see in the picture, its user interface consists of a display screen that takes up most of the real estate, leaving just three rounded buttons at the bottom—search, history and random. Turn it on using another switch located at the top right-hand edge of the device.

It'll take only a second to boot up and present you with the keypad that takes up around 40 per cent of the display's bottom

